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Author's Note

This isn't the kind of story I imagined I'd ever write. It's raw, messy, and uncomfortable. It doesn't tie itself up neatly, and it certainly doesn't ask for your sympathy. But it demands honesty and that's something I owe every reader who picks up this book. The man you're about to meet; Johnson Adebayo is not real. But everything he feels is. His mistakes, his pride, his unraveling... they all come from a place many of us quietly recognize, even if we never speak it aloud.

This story is fiction. Let me be clear about that. But it's a fiction stitched from real things: choices people actually make, lines they cross thinking they'll find their way back, and consequences that echo long after the moment has passed. It's a story about youthful arrogance, emotional blindness, and the way life has a brutal talent for humbling us when we least expect it.

Set during Nigeria's National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) year in 2007, a time meant for growth, service, and discovery, it follows a young graduate, full of self-belief and empty of real wisdom, as he stumbles into decisions that haunt him for the rest of his life. This book explores uncomfortable territory. It touches on themes of moral failure, emotional manipulation, and the far-reaching impact of a moment's poor judgment. It's not told to shock but to reflect. Not to excuse but to expose.

You'll find no heroes here. Just a man who learns, too late, that intelligence is not the same as maturity, and charm is not a substitute for character.

I didn't write this story to provoke outrage or to court controversy. I wrote it because stories like these though fictional mirror realities too often buried in silence. And perhaps, in telling it, someone out there might pause before stepping over a line they'll wish they hadn't.

This book is not a confession. But it is a warning.

If you've ever believed yourself invincible...

If you've ever thought the rules didn't quite apply to you...

If you've ever wondered how one decision could alter the course of an entire life. Then this story is yours.

Content Warning: This story deals with inappropriate relationships involving minors, moral compromise, and their lasting consequences. It contains mature themes that some readers may find disturbing.

— Abdulkabir Ojulari

Lagos, Nigeria

Chapter 1: The Journey Begins

It was June, 2007.

The letter arrived on a Tuesday morning, crisp and official, bearing the NYSC logo that every Nigerian graduate recognizes instantly. I held it like a winning lottery ticket, convinced it was my golden doorway into the future I had always imagined. For years, I had pictured myself stepping out of school and into a career with one of the oil companies, the banks, or some multinational where money and prestige seemed to flow effortlessly.

I tore the envelope with a racing heart. Two words leapt at me:

Delta State.

At first, I laughed. To me, Delta State meant Warri, maybe Asaba — bustling cities, nightlife, and business opportunities. I thought of connections waiting to be made, fortunes to be built, a sharp Lagos boy like me carving out a future in the heart of the oil-rich Niger Delta.

How magnificently wrong I was. "

Life in Orientation Camp

The NYSC orientation camp was my first hint that this year would not follow my carefully written script. I arrived at camp with a suitcase full of clothes, toiletries, and all the confidence in the world. Within hours, I realized confidence was the least useful thing inside that bag.

The first shock was registration. Imagine hundreds of graduates, each one sweating under the fierce sun, dragging luggage across sandy ground while trying not to lose their documents. Lines snaked endlessly. Soldiers barked at us for standing incorrectly, for moving too slowly, for existing. The process that should have taken minutes stretched into hours. By the time I collected my uniform; oversized khaki trousers that looked like they were sewn for a farmer in 1962, my optimism had already begun to wilt.

But the real test was the daily routine.

At 4:30 a.m., a bugle blasted through the hostels like an alarm from hell. It didn't matter if you had just managed to close your eyes after battling mosquitoes; you were up. Soldiers stormed the rooms, whistling and shouting, "Fall in! Fall in!" We stumbled onto the parade ground, half-asleep, khaki uniforms hanging awkwardly on our tired frames.

The exercises were relentless: jogging laps, squats, star jumps, push-ups. Soldiers barked instructions with voices that could shatter concrete. Some corps members fainted under the strain; others pretended to faint just to escape. But faint or not, the parade never stopped. The ground shook with the rhythm of boots and the echoes of tired voices singing military chants.

After the drills came food time, which quickly became another battlefield. Queues stretched like rivers. Hungry corps members clutched plastic plates, praying the watery beans, rice, or pap wouldn't run out before it was their turn. When food did reach your plate, it was often barely edible. A spoonful of stew swimming in oil, rice that tasted like it had been boiled without salt, and beans that could double as stones. Bread, when it appeared, was a miracle.

It didn't take long for us to discover the mammy market — a cluster of small stalls inside camp where women sold jollof rice, fried yam, and chilled drinks. The prices were outrageous, but hunger silenced every protest. Many corps members blew through their entire allowance in those three weeks, trading savings for the simple dignity of a decent meal. I, too, found myself negotiating with food vendors as though my future depended on it.

Then came the struggle for water. The taps in camp seemed to work only when the mood struck them. Corps members formed long queues, buckets and jerrycans in hand, waiting for the trickle of water that might appear. When taps dried up, rumors spread like wildfire: “Water is running near the soldiers’ quarters!” Dozens of us would sprint there, only to find another desperate crowd had beaten us. Some of us bribed local villagers to fetch water from wells. Others simply bought sachet water — pure water — and bathed with it. I remember one evening, too tired to chase rumors, I opened five sachets, poured them into a bowl, and called it a bath. That was camp life: survival by any means.

As if hunger and thirst weren’t enough, we had lectures. Long, endless lectures delivered under scorching sun. We sat shoulder to shoulder on wooden benches, packed under makeshift tents, listening to officials drone on about government policies, health awareness, community projects. Their voices blurred into background noise as the heat pressed down on us. Some corps members dozed off, heads nodding like pendulums. Others whispered jokes to stay awake. I often stared at the horizon, daydreaming about Lagos traffic — a chaos I suddenly missed.

Yet, amidst the struggle, there were lighter moments. Evening social nights gave us music, dance, and laughter. Football

matches lit up the camp with shouts and cheers. Some corps members found “camp love” — short-lived romances born of boredom and proximity. Friendships formed quickly, forged in the fire of shared suffering. I found myself bonding with people I’d never have spoken to outside those camp walls. Somehow, in the middle of frustration, we built memories that would last.

But beneath the jokes and games, we all waited for one thing: the posting letters. That was the day everyone talked about, prayed about, worried about. Camp was temporary, but our posting would define the next year of our lives.

The Posting

When the day came, the air was thick with tension. We gathered like gamblers waiting for a jackpot. My hands trembled as I opened my letter. My eyes darted straight to the line that would decide my fate.

SETRACO.

I blinked. Read it again. Then again.

“What’s SETRACO?” I asked anyone who would listen.

Blank stares. Shrugs. Even the camp officials looked confused. One finally told me, "Just report there. If they reject you, we'll reassign you."

It wasn't Shell. It wasn't Chevron. It wasn't the bank jobs I had dreamed of. Instead, it was an unknown company in a town I had never heard of. Still, I held onto stubborn optimism. Maybe it was a construction giant. Maybe it was a hidden opportunity.

I packed my bag and began the long journey to a place called Bomadi, armed with nothing but hope and the misplaced confidence of someone who had never truly failed at anything important.

The Journey to Bomadi

Each leg of the journey stripped me further of illusion. From Lagos to the crowded motor parks, to the dusty roads of Delta State that grew narrower and lonelier the deeper we traveled, my dreams of corporate air-conditioned offices seemed to evaporate with each passing mile.

By the time I reached Bomadi at 6 p.m., I was exhausted, dusty, and barely holding onto optimism.

Then came the final blow.

SETRACO rejected us.

Not just me, but several other corps members were turned away at the gates. We stood outside like refugees, official posting letters clutched in our hands but suddenly worthless. One girl burst into tears, and I saw my own shock reflected in her eyes.

No accommodation. No food. No electricity. No plan.

We wandered through Bomadi's dimly lit streets like lost souls, chasing rumors of a "corpers' lodge" near the government secondary school. That's when Muiyiwa appeared, a fellow corps member who had been in Bomadi for months. He looked at our weary faces and smiled knowingly.

"Come with me," he said simply.

At the lodge, we finally ate real food, took real baths, and lay on real mattresses. It felt like paradise after days of uncertainty. As I lay on my back that night, listening to the strange sounds of the creek outside, I knew deep down this year would change me.

The universe has a way of humbling certainty. Just when you think you know your path, it throws you into waters you never imagined.

That first night in Bomadi, staring at the ceiling, I thought I was beginning an adventure.

I had no idea I was beginning a reckoning.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 2: First Impressions

Two weeks later, after endless journeys between dusty government offices in Ughelli, files stamped and re-stamped by clerks who barely looked up from their desks, the postings finally came through. No one cheered. No one clapped. We had all learned by then that dreams and reality rarely walked the same path.

That was the day my fantasy of networking with future oil executives died quietly.

I was no longer the young graduate with plans of entering the corporate world. I was now Corper Johnson, mathematics teacher at Government Secondary School, Bomadi.

The irony struck hard. I was an economics graduate sent to teach mathematics in a riverine village where generators only sputtered to life when someone had fuel to spare. But life does not wait for your approval. It moves forward, dragging you along, until one day you find yourself adjusting to the new rhythm as if it had always been yours.

Within a week, I began to settle into the pace of village life. Morning assembly became a familiar ritual. The students sang the

national anthem with such loud voices that I sometimes wondered if their energy alone could power the broken microphone on the assembly ground. They sang with pride, a kind of raw patriotism that felt strange to me, a Lagos boy used to rolling his eyes at ceremonies.

My first days in the classroom were chaotic. The chalk dust clung to my fingers. The blackboard was so worn it seemed to swallow the white lines I drew. The wooden desks creaked under the weight of restless students. Yet slowly, a rhythm emerged. My Lagos accent fascinated them, and my stories of city life earned me a celebrity status I never imagined. I would explain fractions through the price of bus fares in Oshodi, or use the cost of tomatoes in Balogun Market to make equations feel alive. And each time their eyes widened in sudden understanding, something shifted in me.

It felt good. It felt purposeful. I was teaching, and they were learning.

But village life was not without struggle.

Electricity was a luxury. Most evenings I sat by the light of a candle or kerosene lamp, the air heavy with the smell of smoke and insects buzzing at the edges of the flame. Water had to be

fetches in buckets from hand-dug wells or narrow streams. Food was simple: garri, rice, fish when the river blessed the fishermen. There were no cinemas, no bars, no shopping malls, no distractions of city life. Just the slow, steady rhythm of Bomadi and its people.

The town itself was a maze of wooden houses and muddy paths, canoes sliding across the creek like silent messengers. The evenings echoed with the sound of crickets, drums from far-off compounds, and sometimes the laughter of children running barefoot in the dark. In those moments, when I sat outside my lodge listening to the symphony of the village, I wondered if this was punishment or a strange kind of gift.

At school, however, I began to notice something else. Something I could not ignore.

It started with students lingering after class. At first, they asked harmless questions about lessons. Then the questions grew unnecessary, stretched out, repeated. Girls who had solved equations perfectly suddenly claimed confusion just so I could explain again. Their eyes followed me with an intensity I had never known in a classroom. Whispers spread in corners. Laughter broke out whenever I passed.

I brushed it off. I told myself it was natural curiosity. I was young, from Lagos, different. Teachers everywhere deal with student crushes. I convinced myself it was nothing to worry about.

But I should have worried more.

One Thursday evening, the town was wrapped in its usual darkness. The generator at the school had been out of fuel for days, and the candle on my desk cast long shadows across my room. I was grading exercise books, my pen scratching tiredly across the pages, when I heard the knock.

It was soft, almost hesitant.

"Who is it?" I asked, frowning.

"It's me, Corper Johnson." The voice was familiar, gentle.

"Please, I need help with mathematics."

I opened the door, and there she was. Grace. Not her real name, but that is what I will call her. She was one of my students, holding a mathematics textbook against her chest. The flickering candlelight caught her face, and for a moment I saw both the

innocence of a schoolgirl and something else I could not quite place.

"Sir, I was struggling with logarithms," she said, her voice low. "I couldn't sleep. I kept thinking about the problem you gave us. Please, I need to understand it."

I looked at my watch. It was past nine at night. My instincts tightened. Everything about the situation felt wrong.

"Grace, it's late," I said as gently as I could. "Why don't we go over it tomorrow during class?"

Her face fell, and I saw disappointment cloud her eyes. She shifted her textbook nervously. "Please, sir. I really need to understand it tonight. I won't be able to sleep."

Her plea tugged at me. Here was a student, apparently so committed to learning that she would leave her dormitory at night to seek help. Wasn't this the kind of dedication teachers dream about? But even as I considered it, another voice inside me screamed that this was wrong. Dangerous.

"It is best you return to your dormitory," I said firmly, though my tone remained kind. "We will go over everything tomorrow, properly."

She nodded reluctantly and turned away. But as she stepped off the uneven patch of ground outside my door, her foot slipped. Without thinking, I reached out to steady her.

That was when everything shifted.

She didn't just take my hand. She leaned into me, pressed closer, and before I could react, she wrapped her arms around my torso. In that same breathless moment, she kissed me.

It was soft. Quick. Completely unexpected. For five bewildering seconds, the world fell silent. My mind froze, every thought tangled in shock.

Then reality crashed back like a tide. I pulled away, my heart racing in my chest.

"Grace," I said, my voice unsteady, "you need to go. Right now."

For a long second, she held my gaze. There was something in her eyes I could not name...disappointment, defiance, or perhaps

confusion. Then she whispered “Okay” and melted back into the shadows.

I shut the door and stood in the silence of my room, staring at the trembling flame of the candle. My chest tightened as the weight of what had just happened pressed down on me.

I paced. I sat. I stood. I lay down, only to rise again. Sleep mocked me that night. The kiss had lasted no more than a handful of seconds, but it had torn a hole through the boundary that was supposed to protect both teacher and student.

I had stopped it before it went further. But the truth was undeniable. I had still let it happen at all.

And that truth would haunt me for the next twenty years

Chapter 3: Lines Drawn in Sand

The next morning arrived with the weight of a sleepless night pressing heavily on my shoulders. When I finally drifted into slumber, it had not been restful. My dreams had been fragmented, a twisted collage of whispers, candlelight, and the lingering sensation of lips that should never have touched mine. Waking up felt less like relief and more like being dragged into another round of internal wrestling. I told myself it was a new day, a clean slate, but deep down I knew the memory of last night was not something I could simply shake off.

At the morning assembly, I stood in line with the other teachers and let my eyes scan the sea of students. Almost against my will, I searched for her face. And there she was. Grace stood tall among her classmates; her eyes fixed on the flag as she sang the national anthem with conviction. She looked so normal, so utterly unaffected by what had happened only hours before, that for a fleeting moment I wondered if I had imagined the whole incident. Perhaps it had been some strange hallucination born of fatigue and candlelight. But no amount of wishful thinking could erase the fact that I remembered every second too clearly.

Maybe, I thought, we could pretend it never happened. Maybe we could bury the memory under the mountain of routines that made

up school life and keep things strictly professional. But even as I tried to convince myself, another part of me whispered that I was only fooling myself.

Later that morning during mathematics class, I decided to test something. Call it curiosity, call it instinct, I simply needed to know. I looked at her as she sat among the other students, head bent, jotting notes diligently as if she had no care in the world.

"Grace," I said, keeping my tone casual, "come and solve this problem on the board."

It was a logarithm problem, the very type she had claimed had driven her to knock on my door the night before. The classroom fell silent as she stood, adjusted her uniform, and walked confidently to the front. Without hesitation she picked up the chalk, wrote down the first steps, and in a matter of seconds unraveled the entire problem. Her method was precise, her handwriting neat, her explanation flawless.

The students murmured in appreciation. Some clapped lightly. A few looked at her with admiration. But I just stood there frozen, the cold truth washing over me. She had never needed my help with logarithms. The visit had not been about academics. The book in her hand, the pleading tone, the story about

sleeplessness; every bit of it had been theater, carefully constructed for reasons I could not yet understand.

My chest tightened as I forced myself to nod approvingly, pretending nothing was amiss. Inside, however, I was unsettled. Why had she come to my room? Was she testing me? Was it some kind of dare among her friends? Or was it simply a teenager's confused attempt to express emotions she did not fully understand?

For the rest of that day the question gnawed at me. It hovered over my meals, whispered in my ears during class, and followed me into the quiet of my room at night.

Weeks slipped by, and I forced myself into a routine of rigid discipline. I avoided being alone with any female student. I kept all discussions within the safety of the classroom or in the presence of other teachers. My every move was calculated, almost militaristic in its caution. To the outside world I appeared composed, dedicated, and professional, but inside I was walking on eggshells, terrified of another misstep.

Slowly the incident began to blur in the background of everyday life. I taught, graded papers, joined fellow corps members for evening conversations at the lodge, and even learned to laugh

again. Yet the memory lingered, like a faint scar beneath the skin, not visible to others but always there.

One quiet Sunday afternoon, after returning from church, I spotted Grace near the village market. She was in the company of other girls, their laughter carrying easily across the narrow streets. She saw me, smiled brightly, and waved as if nothing unusual had ever transpired between us. I managed a polite nod and quickened my steps, relieved that the interaction had been harmless and appropriate. I told myself that perhaps we had both moved on.

But fate is rarely that simple.

Barely thirty minutes later, there was a knock at my door. My pulse quickened immediately. When I opened it, she was standing there alone, composed, her expression unreadable.

I did not waste time with pleasantries. The question that had burned in my mind for weeks spilled out of me. "Why did you come to my room that night pretending you needed help with mathematics when you clearly knew the work?"

She did not look away. Her eyes met mine with calm certainty. No embarrassment, no excuses. "I just like you," she said softly. "I wanted to be around you."

Her honesty struck me harder than any elaborate lie could have. There was no game, no hidden agenda, just the disarming confession of a teenager who could not yet grasp the depth of what she was admitting.

"That does not make it right," I said quietly, struggling to steady my voice. "I am your teacher. This cannot happen. It is wrong on every level."

She nodded slowly, as though she had expected that answer all along. Rising to her feet, she moved toward the door. Just before stepping out, she paused, glanced back at me, and whispered, "Corper Johnson, you are a good man."

The door clicked shut behind her, but her words remained, echoing in the silence of the room. You are a good man.

For days I could not shake that phrase. Had that night been some sort of moral test? Not from the school administration, not from her parents, but from the universe itself? Was I being examined in ways I could not fully comprehend?

If it was a test, perhaps I had passed. I had maintained boundaries, sent her away, resisted temptation. I had acted like the adult, the teacher, the protector I was supposed to be. But deep inside, unease remained. Passing one test did not mean the trials were over. Life rarely works that way.

What I did not know then was that this was only the beginning. A line had been drawn in the sand, yes, but storms have a way of washing away the clearest boundaries. And the next storm was already gathering.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 4: When Boundaries Blur

Three weeks had passed, and I convinced myself that I had everything under control. Grace and I had fallen into a rhythm, a pattern that seemed respectable on the surface. She came by in the evenings sometimes, always in the company of other students, and always in public view. The visits usually turned into friendly competitions of Scrabble or chess, where the laughter from our small gatherings spilled into the night air. To anyone watching, I was nothing more than a young teacher encouraging bright students, mentoring them with games and conversations about academics, goals, and the promise of the future.

That was the lie I fed myself, the one that let me sleep at night. I told myself I was being a responsible role model. That I was helping a talented young mind focus on her dreams of university, of leaving the village behind for something greater. I even believed, or pretended to believe, that this arrangement had clear boundaries. Somewhere in the back of my mind, however, I knew the truth. I was walking a thin line, one that could blur with the slightest shift in circumstance.

The evening that changed everything began like any other. Grace had come over for a game of Scrabble, her usual mischievous smile lighting up the room as she laid down clever words that

often put me on the defensive. She was a sharp player, patient and calculating, and I had grown to look forward to those games more than I cared to admit.

Halfway through our match, the first drops of rain tapped against the tin roof. At first, it was the gentle drizzle of an ordinary evening, the kind you could walk through with only mild discomfort. But within minutes, the sky split open. Thunder cracked so loudly it shook the thin wooden shutters, and rain poured down in torrents so heavy it seemed the world outside had been swallowed in water. The sound on the roof was deafening, like a thousand hands beating drums all at once. The paths that wound through the village were quickly transformed into rivers of mud.

By ten o'clock, the storm had not let up. By midnight, it had only grown angrier, turning the night into a cage of water and noise. Grace sat quietly for a long while, her eyes watching the curtain of rain beyond the doorway. Then, almost in a whisper, she said the words that made my chest tighten.

"Maybe I should just sleep here tonight."

The words were not spoken loudly, but they carried a weight that pressed down on the room. My heart pounded as I searched for a response, something firm yet kind.

"But... how?" I asked, though I regretted the question the moment it left my lips. "I only have one bed."

It was meant as a boundary, as a subtle way of saying no without confrontation. But instead of retreating, she simply stood, walked over to the bed, and stretched herself across it with the ease of someone making the most natural choice. She lay back, adjusted the pillow beneath her head, and closed her eyes as though the matter had already been decided.

I spent that night on the hard floor, my back pressed against the wall, staring into the shadows. I could hear her breathing, steady and calm, while inside me raged a battle I had not anticipated. Every rational thought screamed that this was wrong, dangerous, a situation that could only lead to destruction. Yet another part of me, one I was too ashamed to acknowledge, was intensely aware of her presence only a few feet away. The storm outside became an echo of the one within me, relentless and unforgiving.

By morning, I told myself I had done the right thing. I had stayed on the floor. I had not crossed the line. My integrity, I thought,

was still intact. Yet when Grace stepped out of my room just after dawn, the sight of her leaving was all Muiyiwa needed to fill the air with jokes and insinuations.

He spotted her, raised his brows, and grinned knowingly. "Ah, my brother," he chuckled, his voice filled with mischief. "Next time, make sure your visitors leave before daylight. You know how people talk around here."

His words were meant as banter, but they pierced me like prophecy. I forced a laugh, pretending to brush it aside, but inside my stomach churned. Nothing had happened, but in a place like that, perception was reality, and reality could be twisted by whispers faster than truth could catch up.

That evening, desperate to clear my mind, I walked through the village under a calmer sky. The storm had scrubbed the air clean, leaving behind the scent of wet earth. My feet carried me aimlessly until I found myself in front of a small roadside shop. There she was, Joy.

She sat with her textbooks spread around her in neat piles, her head bent in concentration, a pen moving quickly across the page. She looked up when I approached, her expression softening into a shy yet confident smile.

"Preparing for JAMB?" I asked.

"Yes," she replied, her voice carrying quiet determination.

"University of Ibadan. Economics."

We began to talk, and the conversation flowed effortlessly. Joy was different. She carried herself with a maturity that made her feel closer to my own age. Her words were measured, her laughter unforced, her dreams clear and practical. She spoke of her ambitions with a certainty that impressed me, and for the first time in weeks, I felt like I was on familiar ground. With her, I was not a mentor or a guardian figure. I was simply myself, engaging with someone whose outlook matched my own.

By the time I returned home later that night, tired but oddly refreshed, a note waited for me beneath my door. The handwriting was neat but unmistakably hers. "Where did you go? I'll check back later. G."

I folded the note without reading further. I did not want to complicate what had been a simple, refreshing evening. That night, I lay in the dark, determined to put distance between myself and the confusion that had begun to choke me.

The next day, I sought Joy out again. Talking with her was easy. It lifted the weight that had begun pressing on me each time Grace's presence lingered too close. That evening, Joy visited my room, and though I kept the lantern dimmed for privacy more than for atmosphere, her laughter filled the space like light. We spoke, we laughed, and when her hand brushed against mine, the kiss that followed felt natural, unburdened, free of the complicated entanglements that had defined my interactions with Grace. It was simple, human, and real.

When I walked Joy home later that night, another note awaited me at my door. I slipped it into my pocket without opening it, clinging instead to the sweetness of what had just unfolded.

But the next morning, Grace cornered me after class, her eyes sharp with unspoken questions.

"Why have you been avoiding me?" she asked.

I stumbled through an excuse about increased church activities and extra responsibilities, hoping it would be enough to shield both of us from the truth. She nodded slowly, as though accepting my words, and later that day, she arrived with a meal she had prepared herself, banga soup and starch, rich and fragrant, carefully packed.

"I really admire you," she said as I thanked her. "You're kind, and you treat people with respect."

Her words carried a sincerity that unsettled me. I smiled, grateful for her effort, but as she turned to leave, I caught the shimmer of tears in her eyes.

"Am I not beautiful enough?" she whispered.

The question struck me harder than any accusation could have. Her voice trembled; her vulnerability laid bare in that small, dimly lit room. In that moment, all my careful rationalizations crumbled. Instead of sending her home, instead of calling another teacher, instead of doing what I knew in my heart was right, I tried to console her.

And in doing so, I crossed the line.

It was the mistake that would haunt me for decades to come, the moment when blurred boundaries dissolved completely, leaving behind consequences I was not yet ready to face.

Chapter 5: The Point of No Return

Content Warning: This chapter deals with serious moral compromise

What happened next... God help me, I still can't find adequate words for it twenty years later.

All I wanted was to stop her tears, to make her feel valued and beautiful, to ease the pain I saw in her eyes. But somewhere in that moment of misguided compassion, I crossed a line that can never be uncrossed.

She was... she was unlike anything I'd expected. Mature in ways that confused and captivated me. Present in a way that made rational thought impossible. When she left, it was with a smile that communicated everything and nothing.

"I'll be back this evening," she whispered.

But after she left, something inside me shattered completely.

The guilt hit like a physical blow. My conscience, which had been whispering warnings for weeks, now screamed at me with the volume of air raid sirens. I couldn't sit still. I couldn't eat. I couldn't think about anything except the magnitude of what I'd just done.

I considered calling my pastor. I thought about confessing everything, turning myself in, surrendering to whatever consequences awaited. A thousand thoughts raced through my

head; police, parents, career destruction, legal consequences, moral ruin but I couldn't act on any of them.

The shame was suffocating.

When morning came, I couldn't face teaching. Couldn't stand in front of a classroom and pretend to be a moral authority figure when I'd just committed an act that could destroy everything. I called in sick and spent the day staring at walls, wondering how I'd become someone I didn't recognize.

This could ruin me. Professionally, legally, morally. This was the kind of mistake that ends careers, destroys reputations, lands people in prison.

So I did what cowards do: I ran.

I packed a bag and fled to Warri, far enough to feel safe but close enough to hear if they came looking for me. For five days, I lived like a fugitive. Every knock on the hotel door, every phone call, every unexpected sound sent my heart racing. I expected the worst—police, angry parents, school officials, journalists, anyone who might have discovered what I'd done.

But nothing happened.

No calls from the school. No angry parents banging down doors. No police investigations. The world continued spinning as if nothing had changed, while I sat in a Warri hotel room wrestling with demons, I'd never imagined I possessed.

After five days of self-imposed exile, I returned to Bomadi cautiously, ready to flee again at the first sign of trouble.

There was no trouble. Just missed calls from Joy—lots of them—and messages asking where I'd been. When we finally met, I lied smoothly, telling her I'd been sick and needed medical treatment in the city. She believed me completely, was even concerned about my health.

She came to see me that evening, sat on my lap while we talked and laughed like nothing had changed. Her presence was comforting, normal, a reminder of what healthy relationships felt like.

Then came the knock that nearly stopped my heart.

"Who is that?" I asked, though my voice barely qualified as a whisper.

The door opened slowly, and there she was...Grace, looking confused and hurt as she took in the scene before her.

"Sister?" she said, staring at Joy. "What are you doing here? And why are you sitting on his lap?" My mind went completely blank.

The room seemed to tilt on its axis.

"Sister?" I managed to croak out.

I turned to Joy with what must have been a look of absolute horror. "Wait... you two are related?"

Joy's response was matter-of-fact, innocent of any hidden meaning. "Yes, that's my younger sister. She's only fifteen years old."

Fifteen. Years. Old.

The words hit me like a physical blow. Blood drained from my face. My hands went numb. I thought I might collapse right there on the spot.

Fifteen years old.

Grace looked at both of us, processing the situation with a maturity that made everything worse. "You're a corps member," she said quietly to Joy. "I'll come back later." And she left. I chased after her, found her sitting outside crying, not just crying but weeping in a way that cut through me like broken glass.

I tried to explain, tried to apologize, tried to make sense of the senseless. "I didn't know you were sisters. You're the one who... I never meant to... this wasn't supposed to..."

But what words could possibly make any of this right? When I returned to Joy, she was worried about my obvious distress. "Why do you care about her so much?" she asked, genuinely puzzled by my reaction.

She assured me not to worry, that her sister wouldn't say anything to anyone. But sitting there, looking at Joy's innocent face, I realized she had no idea what had really happened. No idea that the man she was dating had just committed an act that could destroy everything we'd built together.

"Please excuse me," I said. "I need to rest."

But rest never came. How could it? I had become someone I didn't recognize; someone I'd never imagined I could become. And this was only the beginning of the nightmare.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 6: Angels and Devils

The next morning

As Joy left my room, I tried desperately to fall back to sleep, but my mind refused to grant me that mercy. The weight of what I'd done, what I'd discovered, what I'd become pressed down on me like a collapsing building.

When I finally woke later that morning, my phone showed several missed calls from Grace. I tried calling back, but she didn't answer. My hands trembled as I prepared breakfast. I hadn't eaten dinner the night before, having fallen asleep in a haze of guilt and confusion.

The knock came around noon. Grace stood at my door; her eyes still red from tears that had clearly lasted through the night.

"Did you tell anyone about... what happened between us?" I asked, dreading the answer. "Yes," she said simply.

My heart stopped. "Why would you do that?"

"It was just my friend Queen. She's my best friend from another school." "Who's Queen?" I asked, though part of me didn't want to know.

"She's like a sister to me. I tell her everything."

Grace broke down again, explaining she hadn't slept, that she'd cried all night. But it wasn't because of what had happened between us, it was because she'd discovered I was dating her sister. The betrayal

she felt wasn't about the inappropriateness of our relationship; it was about the competition. She wanted me to leave Joy and be with her exclusively.

I didn't know what to say. The twisted logic of it all made my head spin. But then something unexpected happened: despite her pain, Grace agreed to what she called a "lowkey" arrangement. She would remain quiet about everything if she could still see me, even while Joy remained the "main" girlfriend.

I should have been horrified by this proposal. Instead, I felt relieved. The immediate crisis seemed contained, manageable.

That evening, trying to clear my head with a walk, I saw Grace chatting with another girl near the school compound. She spotted me and called out cheerfully.

"Corper! Come meet my friend; Queen, the one I told you about." I'd heard the name "Queen" mentioned countless times in Grace's conversations, but nothing could have prepared me for the reality of meeting her.

She was... indescribable. Not just beautiful—that word seemed completely inadequate. She possessed the kind of presence that made you forget where you were, what you were doing, why you'd come to that place. When she smiled, it was like someone had suddenly illuminated a darkened room.

We exchanged polite greetings, and I forced myself to leave them there, but Queen's image stayed burned into my mind with photographic clarity.

That weekend, I traveled to Warri to buy essentials, a generator, television, DVD player. Life without electricity in Bomadi was becoming unbearable, and I desperately needed distractions from the chaos in my head.

At the motor park, boarding a vehicle back to Bomadi, I heard a familiar voice calling out: "Corper! Have you forgotten me? I'm Grace's friend."

It was Queen. I'd been staring at her without recognition, mesmerized again by her presence, wondering where I'd seen this stunning woman before.

"I was just trying to figure out where I knew this angel from," I said, laughing nervously at being caught staring. She smiled; a smile that seemed to light up the entire vehicle and settled into the seat beside me.

We talked throughout the journey. She was easy to talk to, intelligent, possessed of a maturity that seemed to transcend her years. When fatigue hit us both, she dozed off with her head resting on my shoulder. My shoulder ached from the awkward position, but I didn't dare move. There was something almost sacred about the moment.

When we reached Bomadi, she helped me carry my purchases to my room before heading home. "I'll come back this evening to watch a movie, once you've got everything set up," she said.

As she was leaving, she paused and asked, "Corper, did you really mean it when you said I look like an angel?"

"Yes," I replied without hesitation. "You absolutely do."

She blushed beautifully. "Thank you. See you this evening."

I suggested she come with Grace, but Queen's smile turned mysterious. "Let's not bother her. If she's available, we'll come together otherwise, I'll come alone."

That evening, Joy arrived with dinner, surprised and pleased to see my new electronics. We ate together, shared some intimate moments, and she mentioned that both she and Grace would be busy with choir rehearsals at church that evening.

Later, Queen returned. Alone.

She was stunning in a way that made coherent thought nearly impossible. When she hugged me warmly in greeting, I managed to ask, "Why didn't you come with Grace?" Her smile was playful, almost mischievous. "She went out with her boyfriend."

I knew she was lying; Joy had already told me about choir practice. But Queen's beauty was so overwhelming, so completely intoxicating, that I found myself not caring about the contradiction.

As she talked, I watched her lips move but couldn't concentrate on her words. My mind raced with thoughts I couldn't control, desires I knew were absolutely wrong but couldn't suppress.

Then, without conscious decision, without rational thought, I leaned in and kissed her.

She didn't resist. When I pulled back immediately, ashamed of my impulse, I started to apologize. "It's okay," she said softly. "Are you sure you're human?" I whispered, half-joking but half-serious.

That's how we fell. That's how the devil got hold of both of us. I felt completely enchanted, utterly under her spell. In that moment, it felt like I was kissing an angel, but I knew the truth was far darker.

I begged her not to tell anyone, to keep everything between us. She agreed, but with conditions I was too intoxicated to properly consider.

I agreed immediately, not even asking what those conditions were. I was already too far gone to care about the details.

The angel had become another kind of temptation entirely, and I was falling faster than I ever imagined possible.

Chapter Seven: Living Three Lives

One month had passed since I had begun living a life that could only be described as chaotic, exhilarating, and terrifying all at once. Balancing three relationships in a village where every whispered conversation and stolen glance could become tomorrow's headline was like attempting to juggle flames while walking a tightrope high above an empty abyss. One slip, one careless word, and everything I had meticulously constructed could shatter into a million pieces.

Joy had started spending Saturday nights at my place. She claimed it was to create a quiet environment for her JAMB preparations, a space free from the constant interruptions of home. Her parents had already been told she was staying over with a friend. But the complication was Queen. She had also announced she would visit that evening, promising to leave by ten to avoid suspicion.

Panic surged through me. I constructed a careful story for Queen, weaving a narrative that my church deacon would be visiting that night to work on a project. I suggested she come early the next morning, when privacy would be guaranteed. And so it went, lie upon lie, each one delicately balanced atop the last. My life had become a house of cards, one that required vigilance, memory,

and an almost obsessive attention to detail to prevent its collapse.

Each relationship demanded a different version of myself. With Joy, I became a mentor, the steady hand guiding her through the complexities of exams and aspirations. With Grace, I was a forbidden romance, a secret she could not share, a thrill wrapped in shadows. Queen required yet another persona, one that existed almost outside of logic, a strange chemistry between us that neither of us fully understood but both of us enjoyed.

Maintaining these separate identities was exhausting. I had to memorize every word, every excuse, every small detail I had shared with each girl. I had to navigate the tightrope of coherence, always fearful that a single story would intersect with another, that one question could expose me, that one moment of carelessness would unravel everything.

Then, one morning, my precarious balance almost came crashing down. I heard through the village grapevine that Grace's father was looking for me. My blood froze. Why would he be searching for me? Had someone seen something? Had one of his daughters confessed? Had my secret been discovered?

Sleep eluded me that night. By dawn, I had packed a small bag with essentials, preparing for the possibility of a hasty departure to Warri. But as fate would have it, I did not need to run. As I stepped outside, there he was. The man himself, walking toward me with a calm, unassuming smile.

"Good morning, corper," he said warmly. "I've been looking for you."

My heart threatened to leap from my chest. I braced myself for confrontation, for anger, for something I could not control.

Instead, he reached into his bag and produced a brand-new iPhone, still in its box.

"My son sent this from Lagos," he explained. "I need help setting it up so I can use my SIM card."

Relief washed over me. We spent a few minutes configuring the phone, and then he departed, leaving me trembling slightly but profoundly grateful that this encounter had ended harmlessly.

My complicated arrangement continued. Grace alone knew about Joy, while Queen only knew about Grace. It was a delicate equilibrium, a "romantic timetable" I maintained with painstaking care. Joy's visits were primarily academic, her nights spent buried

in books and exam preparation. Her dedication motivated her studies, and somehow, our clandestine connection fueled her determination.

When the time came for her exams, she traveled to Bayelsa to write her UTME. The choice of location puzzled me, but it left me alone with the two girls who remained oblivious to each other's existence.

Everything seemed manageable until the night Grace was with me. We were wrapped in a moment of intimacy when a knock at the door jolted me upright. My heart lurched. The voice that followed sent shivers down my spine.

"Corper, it's me."

Grace's eyes widened in terror. "It's my father," she whispered, disappearing under the bed in a heartbeat. I threw on clothes, took a measured breath, and stepped outside, closing the door behind me as carefully as I could.

"Sir, do you need something?" I asked, my voice as steady as I could make it.

He handed me his phone. "My son called, but I couldn't hear him."

I looked at the device. It had been muted. Unmuting it, I handed it back, and he thanked me as if I had performed a miracle. Then he added casually, "Do you know my daughter Grace? She is a student at your school."

My mouth went dry. "Grace? No, sir. What about her?"

"I need her to bring three tubers of yam tomorrow. Thank you."

As he walked away, I hurried inside, my mind racing. "You have to leave now," I told Grace. "It's too dangerous."

She looked at me, confusion and fear mingling in her gaze. "How do you know my father?"

"We'll discuss that later," I said, ushering her toward the door.

The next day, Grace arrived at school with a large bag of yams and palm oil. "Why didn't you take this home?" I asked.

She glanced around nervously. "I told him I don't know where you live. I was scared he might follow me."

I realized then just how close I had come to disaster. And I understood, too, that the distance between safety and ruin was narrowing with each passing day. My life, a careful weave of secrets and lies, was beginning to strain under its own weight. The house of cards I had built was trembling, and I was running out of ways to keep it standing.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 8: Cracks in the Foundation

Three weeks later, the near miss with Grace's father should have been my wake-up call. Instead, it only made me more paranoid and secretive. I told myself I was managing the situation, that I had everything under control. I was deluding myself.

The first major crack appeared during the school's inter house sports day. The sun blazed mercilessly over the dusty field as students in their colored house uniforms cheered from makeshift wooden benches. I was there in my crisp white corper uniform, helping organize events, clipboard in hand, trying to look official while sweat dripped down my back. The air was thick with harmattan dust and the excited shouts of teenagers competing in relay races.

I was marking down times for the 100-meter dash when Queen approached with that mischievous smile, I'd grown to both love and fear. She moved like she owned the entire school compound, her uniform somehow managing to look both regulation compliant and effortlessly stylish. Her braids were pulled back in a high ponytail that swayed as she walked, drawing attention from both male teachers and students alike.

"Corper, I've missed you. You've been ghosting me," she whispered, her fingers trailing down my arm in a way that made my skin tingle despite the heat. Her touch was electric, dangerous in broad daylight with hundreds of people around us.

"Just been busy with school activities," I replied nervously, glancing around to see if anyone was watching. Mr. Adebayo, the vice principal, was thankfully engrossed in shouting at some boys who were cheating in the long jump.

She leaned closer, her breath warm against my ear, carrying the scent of her coconut lip gloss. "Or busy with my friend Grace?"

My heart stopped. The clipboard slipped slightly in my sweaty palm. "What do you mean?"

Her laugh was light, melodic even, but her eyes were serious, searching my face for tells. "Nothing. You know girls talk. Just be careful, you're not as slick as you think you are."

Before I could respond, before I could even process the full weight of her words, commotion at the school gate drew our attention. A yellow taxi was pulling up, kicking up a cloud of red dust that made the security guard cover his nose with his shirt.

Through the haze, I saw a familiar figure stepping out with a small suitcase.

Joy! I exclaimed.

She had arrived straight from her exam in Bayelsa, still wearing her formal exam clothes, a navy-blue dress that was now wrinkled from the long journey. Her face lit up when she spotted me across the field, and she began walking toward us with that determined stride I knew so well, weaving between groups of celebrating students.

Queen turned sharply, her posture straightening as she recognized Joy immediately. I watched in slow motion horror as two worlds I'd been desperately trying to keep separate were about to collide right there on the dusty sports field, with half the school as witnesses.

They both looked at me, expectation in their eyes, questions forming on their lips. I felt like a man standing between two oncoming trains, knowing impact was inevitable but powerless to step aside.

"Joy, I thought your exam was tomorrow," I managed, my voice coming out higher than intended.

"It was today," she replied, reaching me and wrapping her arms around me in a warm hug that felt both comforting and damning. "I wanted to be here early, so I came straight from Bayelsa. I couldn't wait to see you."

Queen's eyes narrowed to slits, her gaze moving between Joy's possessive embrace and my obvious discomfort. "You two are... close?"

Joy pulled back but kept one hand on my arm, smiling with the innocent confidence of someone who believed she had nothing to worry about. "Yes, he's been helping me study for months. He's been such a blessing."

"Interesting," Queen said, her tone carrying undertones that made my stomach clench. The single word hung in the air like a threat, like a promise of things to come.

After Queen walked away, her hips swaying with deliberate emphasis as she rejoined her friends who were clearly dying to hear what had just happened, Joy looked at me with suspicion creeping into her warm brown eyes.

"What's going on between you and Queen?"

I lied, naturally, the words tumbling out with practiced ease. "She just flirts with everyone. You know how some of these secondary school girls can be."

But Joy wasn't completely buying it. I could see doubt taking root behind her eyes, the way her smile became slightly forced, the way she didn't lean into me quite as closely for the rest of the day.

That night, she didn't stay over at my place like she usually did, claiming she was tired from the journey and needed to rest at her cousin's house. I knew better. The seed of doubt had been planted, and I could already see it beginning to sprout.

The following week, Grace invited me to a small party her cousin was hosting in their family compound. The invitation came via a hastily written note passed to me during my SS2 English class, her handwriting neat and careful despite the obvious excitement behind the words.

I declined initially, my survival instincts finally kicking in. Too risky, too many variables I couldn't control. But Grace was persistent in that sweet, determined way of hers. She cornered me after school, her eyes bright with anticipation.

"It'll be small and private," she insisted, "just a few friends from church and some family members. My father is traveling to Lagos for business, so we'll have the whole place to ourselves. Please, I really want you to be there."

Against my better judgment, against every alarm bell ringing in my head, I agreed. The way her face lit up, the way she bounced slightly on her toes with excitement, made it impossible to disappoint her.

The party was exactly as advertised – intimate, maybe twenty people scattered around the small but well-maintained family compound. Chinese lanterns were strung between the mango trees, casting colorful shadows that danced with the evening breeze. A small generator hummed in the background, powering a sound system that was playing the latest Afrobeat hits at a respectful volume that wouldn't disturb the neighbors.

About an hour into the party, as Grace and I danced to Burna Boy's "Last Last" under the twinkling lights, her body moving perfectly in sync with mine, someone shouted over the music, "Is that not your other girlfriend?"

I turned, my blood turning to ice water in my veins. Queen was walking through the compound gate with two friends, her eyes

scanning the small crowd of dancers with predatory focus until they landed on me with Grace's arms around my neck.

She walked directly toward us without hesitation, cutting through the dancing couples like a ship through calm water. Her steps were measured, deliberate, each one bringing her closer to the explosion I'd been dreading.

"Wow, Grace. Small world," Queen said when she reached us, her voice carrying easily over the music. "You didn't tell me Corper was your man."

Grace turned sharply, confusion and alarm painting her features. "Excuse me?"

Queen smiled sweetly, but there was nothing sweet about the glint in her eyes. "I guess you didn't know he was mine too."

The music seemed to stop, though I knew it was still playing. Even the generator's steady hum sounded like it paused to listen to the drama unfolding. The other party guests began to notice, conversations dying as heads turned toward our little triangle of destruction.

Grace looked at me like I'd physically slapped her, her eyes wide with hurt and disbelief. "Tell me she's lying."

I opened my mouth, but no words came out. My throat was dry as sand, my tongue feeling thick and useless. The silence stretched between us like a chasm, growing wider with each passing second.

Queen laughed, the sound cold and sharp enough to cut glass. "That's what I thought."

She turned on her heel and walked away, her mission accomplished, leaving devastation in her wake. Her friends followed, whispering excitedly between themselves, already composing the gossip that would spread through the school like wildfire.

Grace stared at me for a long moment, her eyes searching my face for some explanation, some denial that would make this all make sense. When none came, when I continued to stand there like a mute statue, her expression hardened.

"I have to go," she said quietly, her voice barely audible over the music that had resumed playing, oblivious to the personal apocalypse that had just occurred.

She walked away without another word, leaving me standing alone under the Chinese lanterns while the party continued around me as if nothing had happened. But everything had changed. The careful house of cards I'd been building for months had just collapsed, and I was standing in the rubble wondering how I'd ever thought I could keep it standing.

I didn't sleep that night. I lay in my small room, staring at the ceiling fan that barely moved the stifling air, listening to the night sounds of the village; crickets chirping, distant music from other compounds, the occasional motorcycle pattering past. My mind raced through scenarios, damage control strategies, lies I could tell to try to salvage something from this disaster.

But deep down, I knew the truth I'd been running from for weeks. The storm I'd been trying to avoid was finally here, and it was bigger and more destructive than I'd ever imagined. And I realized, with a sinking feeling in my stomach that felt like swallowing stones, that I had no idea how to weather it.

The foundation I'd built my carefully constructed double life on was cracking, and I could hear the whole structure beginning to groan under the weight of my deceptions. Soon, it would all come crashing down, and I would be left standing in the ruins of my

own making, wondering how I'd ever thought I was clever enough to juggle fire without getting burned.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 9: The Unraveling

The next day dawned gray and oppressive, matching my mood perfectly. Heavy clouds hung low over Bomadi like a suffocating blanket, threatening rain that never came. Everything I'd tried to keep compartmentalized was spilling into the open like water through a cracked dam. Grace had discovered Queen, but worse, Queen now knew about both sisters. The careful balance I'd maintained for months was crumbling before my eyes, and I felt powerless to stop it.

I couldn't face any of them. The thought of seeing the hurt in Grace's eyes, the calculating look in Queen's, or the disappointed confusion in Joy's made my stomach turn. My phone buzzed constantly throughout the morning – Joy kept sending messages asking pointed questions about Queen, her tone shifting from curious to suspicious with each unanswered text. I ignored her calls, letting them ring until they went to voicemail.

Grace had turned off her phone completely, probably overwhelmed by the magnitude of the betrayal. In a way, her silence was worse than Queen's fury or Joy's interrogation. It spoke of a pain so deep she couldn't even form words around it.

Queen was spiraling, sending increasingly frantic messages as she tried to make sense of the twisted web, we were all caught in. Her texts ranged from angry accusations to desperate pleas, sometimes within the same conversation thread. She was unraveling just as badly as I was, and knowing I was responsible for her pain only made everything worse.

By noon, I knew I had to act. The smart move; the cowardly move; was to leave Bomadi until things cooled down. I called my Camp Liaison Officer, putting on my most pathetic voice, and told him I was sick and needed urgent medical treatment in Warri. He barely questioned it; corporals were always getting malaria or stomach bugs from the local food and water.

Within an hour, I had packed my small suitcase with trembling hands and fled the village for the second time in my service year. As the commercial bus pulled away from the motor park, kicking up clouds of red dust that obscured the familiar buildings, I felt like a deserter abandoning a battlefield where I'd left casualties behind.

In Warri, I rented a small room in a cheap hotel near the central market, the kind of place that asked no questions and accepted cash up front. The room smelled of disinfectant and stale cigarette smoke, with walls so thin I could hear every

conversation in the neighboring rooms. But it was anonymous, a place where I could disappear from the chaos I'd created.

I switched off my phone for two full days, trying to escape the digital avalanche that I knew was building. For forty-eight hours, I existed in a strange limbo, wandering the busy streets of Warri like a ghost. I ate at different local restaurants, sat in parks watching people live their uncomplicated lives, and tried to imagine what it would feel like to be normal again.

On Sunday morning, desperate for some kind of absolution, I went to a large Pentecostal church near my hotel. The building was modern and air conditioned, filled with well-dressed families who sang with genuine joy. As the pastor preached about forgiveness and redemption, I found myself praying more desperately than I had since childhood.

I promised God that if I emerged from this mess safely, if somehow, I could untangle this web without destroying these three women I'd grown to care about, I would never get involved in something like this again. I would be honest, faithful, simple in my relationships. The promises poured out of me like water from a broken pipe, each one feeling both sincere and hollow at the same time.

On the third day, knowing I couldn't hide forever, I turned my phone back on with trembling fingers. The screen immediately lit up with notifications; missed calls, text messages, WhatsApp alerts. Nearly an hour's worth of reading awaited me, a digital record of the chaos I'd left behind.

Queen's messages came first, a emotional rollercoaster that tracked her psychological journey over the past three days. The early ones were furious, calling me a coward for disappearing when things got complicated. But as hours passed without response, anger gave way to desperation. Her latest messages begged for forgiveness, promising she could handle sharing me with Grace if I would just talk to her, just give her a chance to prove she could make this work somehow.

Grace's messages told a different story entirely. She had been upset and confused after the party confrontation, but my sudden disappearance had transformed her hurt into something else entirely – worry and self-blame. She thought I was angry with her for putting me in that situation, for not being more careful about who might show up to the party. Her messages grew increasingly frantic, promising not to question me anymore about my relationships, no matter who I was with. Even her own sister, she wrote, though she couldn't know how prophetic those words were. She begged me not to abandon her, promising she could

handle anything as long as I didn't disappear from her life completely.

But it was Joy's messages that hit me hardest. The most mature of the three, she had sent just one long, thoughtful text that showed she understood exactly what was happening better than I'd given her credit for. She said she understood why I'd left because of the pressure, that she could see how complicated things had become. Then she revealed something that nearly made me drop the phone – she had a boyfriend in her neighborhood back home, someone she'd been seeing casually but hadn't mentioned because she didn't want to complicate our situation. She would understand, she wrote, if I had developed feelings for someone else during my service year. No threats, no drama, no accusations; just mature, generous acceptance of a situation that should have destroyed her trust in me completely.

Their messages should have made me feel relieved, should have shown me a path forward where somehow everyone could be happy. Instead, they made me feel exponentially worse. Here were three people genuinely caring about me, each in their own way, and I was deceiving all of them about the others' existence. Their kindness felt like salt in a wound I'd inflicted on myself.

The next morning, I quietly returned to Bomadi on the earliest bus, not informing anyone of my arrival. I still had a week of medical leave remaining according to my CLO, so I could move carefully, test the waters before fully emerging from my self-imposed exile.

I stayed in my small room behind Mrs. Akpofure's compound, keeping a low profile, buying food from different vendors than usual, avoiding the spots where I might run into any of the three women who occupied my thoughts. Part of me wasn't fully convinced that their understanding messages weren't some kinds of elaborate trap, that they hadn't coordinated together to lure me back so they could confront me as a united front.

That night, needing air and exercise after being cooped up all day, I took a careful walk down one of the quieter streets that led toward the creek. The village was settling into its evening rhythm – children being called in for dinner, teenagers clustering around the few spots with generator powered phone charging stations, elderly men setting up draught boards under kerosene lanterns.

I was walking slowly, enjoying the relative normalcy, when I spotted Queen in the gathering darkness. She was sitting on some guy's lap outside a local bar, laughing heartily at something he'd whispered in her ear. Her hand rested possessively on his

chest, and she was looking at him with the same intensity I'd seen her direct at me.

I stopped walking, frozen by the sight. Part of me wanted to march over and confront them, to demand an explanation. But a wiser part recognized the hypocrisy of such a reaction. I had no claim to exclusivity, no right to jealousy given my own behavior.

So, I just stood there until she noticed me watching. Our eyes met across the dusty space, and I saw recognition flicker across her face, followed quickly by something that might have been guilt or defiance. I nodded slightly, as if to say I understood the message she was sending, then turned and walked away without a word.

The message was clear: she had other options too. Just like I did.

Later that night, as I lay in bed trying to process what I'd seen, she came banging on my door with the intensity of someone who'd been drinking liquid courage. Her voice carried across the quiet compound as she called my name, pleading for me to let her in so we could talk.

But I didn't respond, didn't move from my bed. I felt humiliated and used, emotions that I knew I had no right to feel but couldn't

shake nonetheless. She sent multiple apologetic messages through my door and on my phone, explaining that what I'd seen meant nothing, that she'd just been trying to make me jealous, to get some kind of reaction from me.

I ignored them all, letting her words bounce off the walls I'd built around myself. Eventually, she gave up and left, her footsteps fading into the night sounds of the village.

I tried to sleep, my mind already working on damage control, planning how to repair things with Grace and Joy without letting them discover each other's existence. I knew I had to be extraordinarily careful – they were sisters, after all, and any mistake, any slip of the tongue, could expose everything to their entire family.

The next day, I replied to both of them, crafting careful messages saying I was still in Warri receiving treatment but feeling better, that I would return by the weekend. Grace was relieved beyond measure, promising to bring me a home cooked meal as soon as I returned. Joy simply sent back a heart emoji and told me to take care of myself.

But my plans for a careful, gradual re-entry into village life were derailed the next morning. I was outside brushing my teeth at the

communal tap, trying to maintain some semblance of normal routine, when Queen appeared like a materialization of all my guilt and confusion.

She looked terrible, her usually perfect hair was wrapped hastily in a headscarf, her clothes wrinkled like she'd slept in them. Her eyes were red rimmed, and I could see the toll the last few days had taken on her.

"Please," she said without preamble, "we need to talk."

I spat out toothpaste foam and looked at her for a long moment. "It's over," I told her bluntly, the words coming out harsher than I'd intended.

She flinched like I'd physically hit her, but didn't back down. Instead, she began explaining what I'd seen the night before, her words tumbling over each other in their urgency. She'd been in a relationship before we met, she said, something complicated that she couldn't just walk away from overnight. Besides, she continued, she knew we could never have a real future together, not with the age difference, not with my status as a temporary corper, and definitely not with the complicated situation involving her best friend and her best friend's sister; though she still didn't know the full extent of that complication.

"I want honesty," she said finally, her voice breaking slightly. "If we're going to continue anything, if there's any part of you that still wants this, then you have to be upfront with me about everything. No more lies, no more secrets."

The irony was crushing. She was asking for the one thing I couldn't give her...complete honesty while standing there offering her own vulnerability like a gift.

We talked. We argued. We circled around truths neither of us was ready to fully speak. And somehow, inevitably, we went back inside my small room. One thing led to another with the desperate intensity of two people who knew they were probably making a terrible mistake but couldn't stop themselves.

In the aftermath, as we lay tangled in my narrow bed with sweat cooling on our skin and the afternoon heat making the air thick and drowsy, she confessed something that made everything even more complicated than I'd thought possible.

"I love you," she whispered against my chest, her voice so quiet I almost didn't hear her over the sound of my own heartbeat. "I know it's crazy, I know we barely know each other really, but I do. And I'm terrified of what that means for my friendship with Grace, for my own future, for everything."

I felt her tears on my skin before I saw them, warm drops that seemed to carry the weight of all our collective confusion and pain.

As we lay there in the fading afternoon light, I realized Queen couldn't fully let me go for the same reason I couldn't let any of them go, we were all trapped in a web of emotions and circumstances none of us knew how to escape. We'd created something that was simultaneously beautiful and destructive, passionate and poisonous.

But the clock was ticking with the relentless certainty of a countdown timer. NYSC would end eventually, in a matter of months now and when it did, all these carefully maintained lies would either have to become sustainable truths or collapse entirely under their own weight.

Looking at Queen's sleeping face, peaceful for the first time in days, I realized with a sinking feeling in my stomach that I wasn't prepared for either outcome. The foundation was cracking, the walls were closing in, and I was running out of time to figure out how to escape the maze I'd built around myself.

Chapter 10: The Final Countdown

Two months before NYSC completion, I was living like a man with a terminal diagnosis who refused to accept his fate. The calendar on my phone showed the countdown in stark digital precision – sixty-three days remaining until the passing out parade. Sixty-three days until I could escape the web, I'd woven around myself in this small village that had somehow become the center of my universe.

Time was running out, and instead of preparing for a clean exit, I found myself making promises I knew I couldn't keep. The words fell from my lips with increasing frequency, each one another thread binding me deeper into deception.

To Joy, during one of our study sessions under the flickering fluorescent light in my room: "If you do well in your final exams, I'll take you with me to Lagos. You're too smart to waste away in this village." Her eyes would light up with hope, and she'd squeeze my hand with excitement about a future I was already planning to deny her.

To Grace, as we walked along the creek path in the purple twilight: "Don't worry about what happens after service. I have plans for us in the city. Lagos is big enough for fresh starts." She

would smile and lean into me, trusting completely in promises that felt like poison on my tongue even as I spoke them.

To Queen, in the heated aftermath of our reconciliations: "We'll figure something out when I leave here. What we have is too strong to just end." She would nod against my chest, her breathing gradually slowing as she allowed herself to believe in possibilities that existed only in the space between midnight and dawn.

Each promise was whispered in private, each woman believing she was the only one receiving such assurances. I told myself I was keeping hope alive, maintaining peace until I could find a graceful way to disentangle myself. But really, I was just delaying the inevitable reckoning, pushing the moment of truth further into a future I hoped would somehow never arrive.

The truth was crushing in its simplicity: I had a fiancée in Lagos. Adunni had been with me since our third year at the university, someone who was now in her final year studying law and expecting to build a future with the man she'd been faithfully waiting for throughout his service year. She sent me pictures of wedding venues she'd been researching, forwarded job postings that might interest me, talked about the flat we'd rent in Victoria Island once I returned and found steady employment.

My focus was supposed to be on preparing for that life, on transitioning back to the person I'd been before Bomadi changed me. Instead, I was drowning in complications I'd created, emotional quicksand that seemed to pull me deeper every time I tried to extract myself.

When the opportunity came to travel to Lagos for two weeks to handle job interviews and make arrangements for my post NYSC life, I grabbed it like a drowning man reaches for a life preserver. I told my three women that the interviews were mandatory, that my future depended on making a good impression with potential employers.

Being back in my familiar environment – the bustling chaos of Lagos traffic, the towering office buildings, the familiar smell of suya and exhaust fumes – I could think clearly for the first time in months. The spell that Bomadi had cast over me began to lift as I walked through the streets of my childhood, visited my parents in their modest home in Surulere, had dinner with Adunni at our favorite restaurant in Ikeja.

Sitting across from Adunni, watching her animated face as she talked about her final year project and our shared dreams, I realized how far I'd drifted from the person she'd fallen in love

with. She was exactly as I'd left her – ambitious, grounded, planning for a future built on solid foundations. Meanwhile, I had become someone who juggled lies like a street performer, someone who made promises to teenagers while planning to abandon them.

I realized how unsustainable everything had become. The web of relationships, the constant mental energy required to keep stories straight, the emotional exhaustion of managing three different versions of myself – it was killing me slowly. Every phone call required careful consideration of which identity to inhabit, every message had to be crafted to avoid revealing information that belonged to another relationship.

I wanted a clean exit, a peaceful end to a chapter that had spiraled far beyond anything I'd originally intended. When I'd first arrived in Bomadi, I'd planned to keep my head down, complete my service quietly, and return to Lagos unmarked by the experience. Instead, I was returning as someone fundamentally changed, carrying secrets that felt like stones in my chest.

When I returned to Bomadi to prepare for the passing out parade, the village felt different somehow. Smaller, more claustrophobic. The familiar sights – the dusty main road, the primary school

where I'd taught, Mrs. Akpofure's compound – felt like pieces of a life I'd already begun to leave behind.

I was emotionally drained, running on fumes and determination. I just wanted to get through the final activities, attend the mandatory farewell events, smile for the ceremonial photographs, and leave quietly without causing unnecessary drama.

Then Grace appeared at my door one evening, looking pale and shaky. She moved differently, more carefully, as if her body had become fragile overnight. Her usual bright energy was replaced by something subdued, almost fearful.

"What's wrong?" I asked, genuinely concerned by her appearance. She looked like she hadn't been sleeping, hadn't been eating properly.

She stood in my doorway for a long moment, gathering courage for words that would change everything. When she finally spoke, her voice was barely above a whisper.

"I'm pregnant."

The words hit me like a physical blow, like someone had reached into my chest and squeezed my heart until it stopped beating.

The world seemed to tilt sideways, and I had to grip the doorframe to keep from falling.

I tried to laugh it off, hoping desperately that I'd misheard, that this was some kind of cruel joke. "Who's responsible?" I asked, though part of me already knew the answer with horrible certainty.

Her gaze was steady, unflinching, holding mine with the directness of someone who had nothing left to lose. "You, of course."

The room seemed to spin. She explained in halting sentences that she'd been trying to act normal so her parents wouldn't notice the changes, hiding morning sickness, making excuses for her tiredness. But she'd already started quietly packing her things, planning to run away with me to Lagos after the passing out parade.

"I know it's not what we planned," she said, tears beginning to roll down her cheeks, "but maybe it's a sign that we're meant to be together. Maybe this is God's way of making sure you don't forget me when you go back to the city."

I heard myself reassuring her that everything was still on track, that we'd find a way to leave together after the ceremony in Asaba. The lies flowed smoothly, automatically, while inside I was screaming. My life in Lagos, my relationship with Adunni, my carefully planned future – everything was about to be destroyed by the consequences of actions I couldn't take back.

That night, I lay awake staring at the ceiling, my mind racing through impossible scenarios. How could I explain a pregnant teenager to my fiancée? How could I bring Grace to Lagos without destroying everything I'd built there? How could I abandon her without becoming the kind of man I'd sworn I would never be?

The next morning, I didn't wait for the school's send forth event that had been planned in my honor. I packed my essential belongings with shaking hands – abandoning the generator and television I'd bought, leaving behind books and clothes that suddenly felt like artifacts from a life I could no longer claim.

I fled to Warri like a criminal escaping a crime scene, checking into the same anonymous hotel where I'd hidden before. But this time felt different, more final. I was burning bridges behind me, cutting ties that could never be restored.

From my hotel room, I kept in touch with Grace through carefully crafted text messages, feeding her lies and false reassurances designed to prevent her from creating a scene that might ruin my passing out parade. I told her I was handling logistical details, making arrangements for our new life together, ensuring everything would be perfect when we finally left Bomadi behind.

On the day of the parade, when she asked where we should meet afterward, I delivered what would become the cruelest lie of my entire service year.

"Wait at home," I told her. "It would be more honorable for me to meet your parents formally and ask for their blessing before we leave together. I want to do this the right way."

Even as the words left my mouth, I knew they were the words of a coward, someone who had chosen the easy path of deception over the difficult road of honesty.

The passing out parade in Asaba was a blur of white uniforms, ceremonial speeches, and forced smiles. I stood with my fellow corps members, listening to officials congratulate us on our successful service to the nation, while my phone buzzed with messages from Grace asking about timing, about when I would come for her.

The moment I received my NYSC certificate, feeling the weight of the document that marked the official end of my service year, I headed straight to Lagos without looking back. I left Grace waiting for a man who was never coming back, believing in promises that had been lies from the moment I'd spoken them.

That evening, as I sat in my childhood bedroom surrounded by remnants of the life I was trying to reclaim, my phone rang. Grace's name appeared on the screen, and I answered with trembling fingers.

Her voice was broken, full of tears and confusion. "Where are you? I've been waiting all day. My parents keep asking questions, and I don't know what to tell them anymore."

I had nothing to say. I stared at the phone, listening to her sobs echo through the speaker, and realized I had become someone I didn't recognize – someone capable of abandoning a pregnant teenager who believed in promises I'd never intended to keep.

Then Queen called. Repeatedly. The phone would ring, I would let it go to voicemail, and within minutes it would ring again. When I finally answered, driven more by exhaustion than courage, she delivered her own devastating news in a voice that was eerily calm.

"I'm pregnant too."

I lost it completely. The phone slipped from my numb fingers, clattering onto the floor as I struggled to process how everything could be falling apart at once. How was this possible? How could both of them be pregnant? How could the universe be this cruel, this perfectly orchestrated in its destruction of everything I'd tried to preserve?

In desperation, hands shaking with something beyond fear, I called Joy. I needed to confirm she wasn't pregnant as well, needed to know that at least one part of this nightmare wasn't expanding beyond my ability to comprehend.

Instead of the reassurance I desperately needed, I got anger, hurt, and a truth that cut deeper than anything else she could have said.

"I know you slept with Grace," she said, her voice cold with betrayal. "I know you've been playing games with all of us. Did you really think we wouldn't figure it out? Did you really think you could keep lying to sisters and expect it to work forever?"

She felt betrayed and used, and she was absolutely right. I had no defense, no explanation that could justify what I'd done to all of them.

The only way I could preserve what remained of my sanity was to block all their numbers and try to move forward. I told myself NYSC was over, that chapter was closed, and Lagos represented a fresh start where I could rebuild the person I'd been before Bomadi changed me.

I was wrong about the fresh start.

The ghosts I'd created would follow me home, carrying consequences I wasn't prepared to face and truths that would reshape my understanding of who I really was beneath all the lies I'd learned to tell so easily.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Chapter 11: Reckoning

Present day, and I am staring at my reflection in the bathroom mirror of our spacious Lekki home, watching a forty-three-year-old man whose success feels like a costume he can never take off. The face looking back at me has aged well – regular gym sessions, expensive skincare products, the kind of polished appearance that comes with a comfortable salary and social expectations. But the eyes tell a different story. They hold the weight of twenty years of unanswered questions, twenty years of guilt that has settled into my bones like arthritis.

I married my fiancée Adunni three months after returning from NYSC. The wedding was everything she had dreamed of – elaborate ceremony at the Civic Centre, reception at one of Lagos's premier hotels, honeymoon in Dubai that filled her Instagram with enviable photos. We built what looked like a successful life together in Lagos, the kind of life that makes other couples jealous at social gatherings. Good jobs – she became a successful lawyer; I climbed the corporate ladder in banking. Nice house with a swimming pool and generator that never fails. Two cars in the driveway, domestic staff, membership at exclusive clubs, annual vacations to exotic destinations.

But we never had children.

For twenty years, we have undergone every medical test imaginable, visited every fertility specialist in Lagos, Abuja, and even flew to London and India for consultations with internationally renowned experts. The results are always the same, delivered in clinical language that fails to capture the devastating simplicity: nothing is wrong with either of us. Her ovulation is textbook perfect. My sperm count is above average. Her tubes are clear, my hormones are balanced. Everything should work, but it doesn't.

The procedures became a ritual of hope and heartbreak. IVF attempts that failed at implantation. Hormone treatments that left Adunni emotionally volatile and physically drained. Adoption applications that somehow never progressed beyond initial interviews. Each failure carved deeper into our marriage, created silences where conversations used to flow, built walls where intimacy once flourished.

Several pastors have told me variations of the same prophecy, delivered with the certainty of men who claim to see into spiritual realms. The most recent was Pastor Adebayo from Mountain of Fire, who looked directly into my eyes during a counseling session and declared with unsettling confidence: "Brother, your past is haunting your present. The seeds you planted and abandoned are

blocking your blessings. Until you return to where you committed these sins and make peace with what you did, ask for forgiveness from the women you wronged, your lineage will remain cursed."

Adunni squeezed my hand during that session, thinking the pastor was speaking metaphorically about general youthful indiscretions. She doesn't know about Bomadi. She doesn't know about the three women who shaped those crucial months of my life. She doesn't know that somewhere in Nigeria, her husband has children he's never acknowledged, never supported, never held.

I went back to Bomadi two years ago, telling Adunni I was attending a banking conference in Warri but taking an extra day for personal business. The journey felt like traveling backwards through time, each familiar landmark triggering memories I'd spent decades trying to suppress. The motor park, the dusty main road, the creek that sparkled in afternoon sunlight.

But it was like searching for ghosts in a place that had moved on without me. The village had changed dramatically – new buildings, paved roads, even a small shopping complex where the old market used to be. Most of the faces were unfamiliar, a new generation that had grown up in my absence. My old contacts had scattered to other states, other countries, other lives.

Mrs. Akpofure, my former landlady, had died five years earlier. The primary school where I taught had been renovated and expanded, with teachers who had never heard my name. The spots where I used to meet Grace, Queen, and Joy had been built over or transformed beyond recognition.

But I did discover something through careful inquiries, conversations with elderly residents who remembered the young corper from decades past. The truth emerged in fragments, whispered revelations that shattered me completely.

Both Grace and Queen had given birth. Grace had a son; my son...born seven months after I fled. Queen had a daughter; my daughter...born six months later. Both children would be around nineteen now, old enough to be in university, old enough to have their own dreams and aspirations, old enough to look in mirrors and wonder whose features they inherited.

The numbers hit me like physical blows. Nineteen years of birthdays I missed, first steps I never witnessed, school plays I never attended, graduation ceremonies where my absence was a hole that could never be filled. Nineteen years of questions they probably asked their mothers: "Where is my father? Why did he leave us? Did he ever love us?"

I have children I've never met, never supported, never acknowledged. Two teenagers growing up somewhere in Nigeria, possibly struggling financially because of my abandonment, possibly excelling despite it, possibly carrying my name or carrying the weight of not having one to carry.

The weight of this knowledge is crushing, a physical sensation that sits in my chest like swallowed glass. Every morning when I wake up in my comfortable bed, every time I pass children playing in our neighborhood, every Father's Day that passes with hollow celebration, I wonder: What do they look like? Do they have my height, my laugh, my tendency to solve problems by running away? Did my son inherit my love for mathematics? Does my daughter have my stubborn streak? Are they in school? Do they need money for fees, books, uniforms? Do they hate the man who gave them life but never gave them presence?

Grace and Queen...where are they now? The village elders couldn't provide current addresses, only fragments of information that raised more questions than answers. Someone thought Grace had moved to Port Harcourt after secondary school. Another person believed Queen had gone to Abuja to live with relatives. Did they manage to finish their education while raising children alone? Did they find good men who became fathers to

my children, who stepped into the void I created? Or did my abandonment trap them in cycles of poverty and struggle, their dreams sacrificed on the altar of my selfishness?

And Joy – the one who got away, who might have been spared the worst of my selfishness because I never got her pregnant – what became of her dreams? Did she make it to university like she planned? Is she living the life of intellectual achievement she used to describe during our study sessions? Or did the betrayal and heartbreak I caused derail her trajectory too?

These questions torment me with the persistence of chronic pain. My wife sees my struggles but doesn't understand their source. She attributes my melancholy to work stress, mid-life crisis, the natural disappointment of our childless state. How do you tell the person you love that your childlessness might be cosmic justice for children you abandoned? How do you explain that your sleepless nights are haunted not by the children you never had, but by the ones you walked away from?

I've tried to make peace with it, tried to convince myself that the past is past, that I can't change what's already been done. I've donated anonymously to orphanages and scholarship funds, as if charity could balance the scales of cosmic justice. I've become a

mentor to young professionals, as if guiding other people's children could compensate for abandoning my own.

But peace won't come. Success feels hollow when it's built on others' pain. The house feels empty not just because it lacks the laughter of children, but because somewhere other houses contain my children's laughter that I've never heard. Happiness feels borrowed, temporary, like something that could be revoked at any moment when the cosmic accountant comes to collect on debts I can never repay.

Sometimes I dream about them – all three women, and the children I've never met. In my dreams, I'm brave enough to tell the truth from the beginning, strong enough to face consequences instead of running from them, man enough to take responsibility for the lives I helped create. In my dreams, Grace and Queen raise our children with fathers who stayed, who contributed, who showed up for soccer games and school concerts. In my dreams, Joy forgives me and we remain friends, and she achieves every dream she ever shared with me during those evening study sessions.

Then I wake up in my air-conditioned bedroom, surrounded by the trappings of success, and I'm still the same coward who ran away twenty years ago. The same man who chose his own

comfort over his children's welfare, who prioritized his own reputation over their right to have a father.

I don't know if redemption is possible for someone like me. I don't know if there's a path back from choices that echoed through decades, creating ripples of pain that spread far beyond my ability to track or contain. But I know that silence isn't working anymore, hasn't worked for twenty years. The truth has a way of demanding to be told, even when – especially when – it's painful enough to destroy everything you've built on lies.

So here I am, telling my story to strangers on the internet, hoping that somehow, somewhere, the people I wronged might know that they haven't been forgotten. That someone remembers the consequences of his actions, even if he was too weak to face them when they mattered most. That in a house in Lekki, a successful banker lies awake at night thinking about children he's never held, wondering if they need school fees or medical care or just a father's presence at important moments.

I don't deserve forgiveness. The words feel inadequate even as I think them, too small to bridge the canyon of pain I created. But I pray for it anyway, in churches where pastors promise that God's mercy extends even to fathers who abandon their children, even to men who build success on foundations of betrayal.

I don't deserve peace. But I search for it every day, in meditation apps and therapy sessions and self-help books that promise healing for wounds that feel too deep to ever properly close.

And somewhere in Nigeria, in Port Harcourt or Abuja or cities I've never even considered, my children are growing up. They're creating their own stories, facing their own challenges, building their own dreams...all without a father who was too selfish and scared to stay and face the music when they needed him most.

If Grace, Queen, or Joy ever read this confession in the vast digital ocean of the internet: I'm sorry. Those words are pathetically inadequate, like offering a band aid for a severed limb, but they're all I have. You deserved better than the boy I was. Your children deserved better than the man I became. You deserved honesty instead of lies, presence instead of abandonment, a partner instead of a coward.

I failed you all, and I'm still learning to live with that failure. Still learning that success without integrity is just elaborate decoration on an empty life. Still learning that you can run from consequences but you can never outrun yourself.

But maybe, just maybe, telling this truth is the first step toward something better. Maybe there's still time to be the man I should have been twenty years ago. Maybe somewhere in Nigeria, two nineteen-year-olds are strong enough, smart enough, accomplished enough to prove that they didn't need their father's presence to become extraordinary.

Maybe there's still time to find them, to try to make amends, to offer what I should have offered two decades ago.

Maybe it's not too late to finally do the right thing.

Abdulkabir Ojulari

Author's Closing Remarks

The story you just read never happened. It is a work of fiction, a narrative constructed from imagination and observation. But the possibility of it happening, the circumstances that could lead to such devastation, exists in communities across Nigeria and beyond. Wherever you are reading this, be cautious. Your actions or inactions can ruin the lives of innocent people in ways you may never fully comprehend.

This tale serves as a mirror, reflecting the dangerous intersection of youth, opportunity, power dynamics, and moral compromise. The protagonist's journey from idealistic graduate to manipulative deceiver didn't happen overnight. It was a gradual erosion of principles, each small compromise making the next larger betrayal easier to justify. This is how good people become capable of terrible things, not through dramatic moral collapse, but through incremental steps away from their better selves.

To young people, especially those in positions of temporary authority like NYSC service, national service programs, or educational roles in unfamiliar communities: understand that your actions carry weight far beyond your immediate circumstances. The teacher who takes advantage of students, the youth corper who exploits their status, the volunteer who abuses trust – these

individuals leave lasting scars on the very communities they were meant to serve. Your temporary assignment will end, but the consequences of your choices will echo through lives and families long after you've returned to your comfortable urban existence.

To parents, guardians, and community elders: know where your children go, whom they spend time with, and what influences shape their daily lives. The three young women in this story were not wayward or promiscuous. They were bright, ambitious teenagers who fell prey to someone who recognized their vulnerabilities and exploited them. Grace sought mentorship and found manipulation. Queen craved excitement and found exploitation. Joy needed academic support and found betrayal. Their stories could be those of daughters, sisters, nieces in any Nigerian community.

Create environments where young people feel safe discussing their relationships and concerns. Too often, teenagers hide relationships from parents out of fear of judgment or punishment, leaving them isolated when they need guidance most. The shame and secrecy that surrounded these relationships made it easier for deception to flourish. Open communication channels, regular check ins, and genuine interest in your children's social lives are not invasion of privacy, they are protective measures in a world where predators often wear friendly faces.

To educators and authority figures: recognize that your position comes with profound responsibility. Students, whether in secondary school or university, are not your peers. They are not candidates for romantic relationships, regardless of their apparent maturity or willingness. The power differential inherent in these relationships makes genuine consent impossible. The teacher who "falls in love" with a student, the boss who pursues an intern, the mentor who crosses professional boundaries – these individuals are not romantic figures. They are abusers who use their authority to exploit those they are meant to protect and guide.

The ripple effects of such relationships extend far beyond the immediate participants. Families are shattered by unplanned pregnancies. Educational dreams are derailed by early parenthood. Young women face stigma and economic hardship while their exploiters move on to comfortable lives. Children grow up wondering why their fathers abandoned them before birth. Communities lose trust in the institutions meant to develop their youth.

Consider the economic dimension of this story. The protagonist used his relative wealth modest by Lagos standards but significant in rural Bomadi to gain access and influence. Material gifts, promises of city opportunities, and financial support became

tools of manipulation. Parents struggling economically may unwittingly encourage relationships that seem to offer their daughters better prospects, not recognizing the exploitation disguised as benevolence. Economic vulnerability should never be a pathway to sexual exploitation.

This narrative also highlights the particular dangers facing young women in educational transition periods – between secondary school and university, during exam preparations, or when seeking mentorship for academic advancement. These are moments of particular vulnerability when young people are hungry for guidance and support. Predators understand this vulnerability and position themselves as helpers, mentors, and pathways to better futures.

To young women specifically: trust your instincts about adults who single you out for special attention, who insist on secrecy, or who gradually escalate physical intimacy under the guise of mentorship. Genuine mentors support your goals without seeking personal gratification. They encourage family involvement rather than demanding privacy. They maintain professional boundaries regardless of your feelings or apparent maturity.

The religious dimension of this story, the protagonist's eventual consultation with pastors about his childlessness reflects a

spiritual understanding of consequences that transcends immediate material success. Whether one believes in divine justice or not, the psychological weight of abandoned responsibilities and betrayed trust creates its own form of punishment. Success built on others' suffering feels hollow because it is hollow. The conscience, however suppressed, keeps careful accounts.

To those who have made similar mistakes: acknowledgment of wrongdoing is the first step toward possible redemption, but it is only the first step. Real accountability requires more than confession to strangers on the internet. It requires attempting to make amends to those you've wronged, even when, especially when such attempts are difficult, embarrassing, or costly. It requires using your experience to prevent others from making similar choices.

This story is ultimately about the long-term cost of short-term thinking. The protagonist pursued immediate gratification while ignoring potential consequences. He prioritized his comfort over others' wellbeing. He chose deception over difficult conversations. Each choice seemed reasonable in isolation but created a pattern that destroyed multiple lives, including his own in ways he's still discovering twenty years later.

The children in this story, now young adults – represent the most tragic dimension of these failures. They bear the consequences of choices they never made, carry the weight of abandonment they did nothing to deserve, and must build their identities around the absence of a father who was too cowardly to face his responsibilities. Their mothers carry the double burden of single parenthood and the knowledge that they were deceived by someone they trusted.

Prevention requires vigilance from entire communities. Schools must maintain strict professional boundaries and clear reporting mechanisms. Parents must stay engaged in their children's lives without being overbearing. Young people must understand that secrecy in relationships is often a warning sign of exploitation. Communities must create cultures where accountability is valued over reputation management, where protecting predators in positions of authority is understood as complicity in their crimes.

The technology that enables modern versions of this story social media, mobile phones, digital payment platforms also create opportunities for detection and prevention. The same tools that facilitate secret relationships can expose them. The same platforms that enable manipulation can be used to educate and warn.

Remember that prevention is always preferable to punishment, that education is more powerful than regulation, and that communities that protect their most vulnerable members are stronger than those that enable exploitation through silence and complicity.

The story you have read is fiction, but the lessons it contains are drawn from real patterns of harm that occur in communities across the world. May it serve not as entertainment but as warning, not as judgment but as education, and not as despair but as motivation to create safer, more accountable communities for all our children.

Wherever you are, whatever your role, you have the power to prevent these stories from becoming reality. Use that power wisely.